Alefiya J Malubhoy (A0226616E)
EN3264 In Other Wor(l)ds: Post-colonial Theory and Literature
Dr Tania Roy
23 November 2023

Selfhood and Sisterhood for the Subaltern

Gayatri Chakraborty Spivak's landmark essay, 'Can the Subaltern Speak?', pierces through the illusion of the postcolonial project as being positioned through the gaze of an uninterested subject. She outlines the figure of the mute subaltern pushed into the shadows by the violence of this Eurocentric knowledge-formation; she then sketches the female as the subaltern who is further ostracised by the hegemony of both race and gender dichotomies. Assia Djebar's 'Women of Algiers in their Apartment', through the naming and characterization of post-independence Algerian women, not only cuts through these totalizing colonial and patriarchal gazes imposed on the female body, but also clears a space — monumentally, across age, race, and class distinctions — for the expression and consolidation of the female identity. In this essay, I attempt to reconstruct Spivak's conceptualization of the subaltern; then, I posit that Spivak's subaltern voice, which runs the constant risk of either gross individuation or obliterating coalescence, emerges in Djebar through a chain of discontinuous narrations that become radically embodied in the feminine space of the public baths.

Towards a Narration of the Subaltern

A brief unpacking of Spivak's provocative titular question, 'Can the Subaltern Speak?', quite succinctly denotes the sheer scope of her analysis: we must ask ourselves several questions implicated in this one phrase. Who are the subaltern? Why can they not speak? Who would they speak to? In the first instance, Spivak says, the impulse to answer these questions from a postcolonialist perspective must be dissuaded. Leveraging on Marx, Derrida and Freud, Spivak deconstructs the inherent contradiction of leftist French intellectuals, namely Foucault and Deleuze, who "valoriz[e] the concrete experience of the oppressed, while being so uncritical about the[ir] historical role [as] the intellectual" (69). In other words, the very discipline and framework of postcolonial study is positioned through the masculine, Eurocentric gaze — the fatal error is that it pretends not to share the same geo-political interests as colonization. The illusion of the "transparent" intellectual (70) who is "masquerading as the absent nonrepresenter who lets the oppressed speak for themselves" (87)

reinscribes in its pedagogy the same imperialist structures it claims to dismantle. As an institutionalised form of knowledge, postcolonial study is complicit in reproducing the colonizer imperative of consuming, exploiting and extracting values from the Third World.

In the course of this "epistemic violence" (76), these intellectuals construct a totalizing and essentialist lens oriented toward the 'Third World' without analyzing the function of political power, economic interest, and desire that the objective of colonization began with in the first place. By "dislocating" the exploitative geopolitical domination of the West (75) and replacing it — as Foucault does — with a pervasive and unthinking power structure, they are unable to recognize, much less follow, the strands of colonial power structures that break down across class divisions in the colonized population. In this way, "the relationship between global capitalism (exploitation in economics) and nation-state alliance (domination in geopolitics) is so macrological that it cannot account for the micrological texture of power" (74). However, the question then arises, if the project of giving the colonized a voice cannot be undertaken by the white intellectual, whether it can be undertaken by the colonized intellectual. Resoundingly, the answer is no. Using her own Indian example, Spivak asserts that such intellectuals are "at best native informants for the first-world intellectuals interested in the voice of the Other" (79). These native informants are only a selectively permeable membrane between the indigenous peoples and Western scholars who cannot engage with them; in attempting to represent the community, they lay over it a homogenizing cover that renders them into a unified entity identifiable only by their impoverishment and victimization, which differentiates them from the informant. The cultural erasure of the colonialist and neo-colonialist is continued in this mode of representation.

The need for expression by the non-intellectuals was recognised and confronted by the Subaltern Studies Group, who attempted to trace peasant insurgencies and thus locate collective forms of agency during the British occupation of India. The group claims the term 'subaltern' from its original Italian usage referencing those excluded from a military hierarchy to mean "the general nonspecialist, nonacademic population across the class spectrum, for whom the episteme operates its silent programming function" (78), the politically invisible, who "can be only an identity-in-differential" (79). However, the attempt to carve the subaltern out by listing the stratification of social

groups (Guha, as in Spivak, 79) is another reproduction of the deceptive transparency that produces a homogenized category of the subaltern. The subaltern, whose only identity is difference, cannot be assimilated into ones, "there is no unrepresentable subaltern subject that can know and speak itself" (80). Turning to the case of the woman, Spivak — powerfully and forcefully — reiterates that the position of the subaltern, dehistoricised and mute, along with "the ideological construction of gender [that] keeps the male dominant" (82), renders the subaltern woman doubly left behind. It is not just that she is oppressed twice over, but that theoretical frameworks assume for her a "pure form of consciousness" (81) that can be uncovered and (but) will eventually be subsumed under the same epistemic violence we have been discussing so far.

The force of two ideological hegemonies weighs on the subaltern woman; Spivak outlines these two forces through the example of the Indian practice of sati, or self-immolation of the widow on the husband's funeral pyre, within two sentences that betray their assumption of women's autonomy. The imperialist aim is "White men saving brown women from brown men"; the patriarchal aim recedes to traditionalist nostalgia by asserting "The women actually wanted to die" (93). The subaltern woman is caught "into a violent shuttling" (102) between colonization and patriarchy — where she "will remain mute as ever" (90). Spivak concludes her pivotal essay with a shocking, painful anecdote, one I cannot summarize in danger of reducing the value of its force:

> A young woman of sixteen or seventeen, Bhuvaneswari Bhaduri, hanged herself in her father's modest apartment in North Calcutta in 1926. The suicide was a puzzle since, as Bhuvaneswari was menstruating at the time, it was clearly not a case of illicit pregnancy. Nearly a decade later, it was discovered she was a member of one of the many groups involved in the armed struggled for Indian independence. She had finally been entrusted with a political assassination. Unable to confront the task and yet aware of the practical need for trust, she killed herself (103).

Bhuvaneswari's suicide subverts the imperialist and patriarchal forces in one fell swoop — her resistance against the white man that claims to emancipate her dismantles the rescue the white man (he) orchestrated for her; further, her suicide also prevents the masculine impulse (to valorize) of valorizing tthe violence of insurgency. She rejects and reassimilates the traditionalist narrative that accuses her of premarital sex and, by association, reduces her life to a man's desire. And yet, despite

this revolutionary eschewing of the hegemonies written onto her, Bhuvaneswari's story is remembered and rehearsed under those hegemonies by other women as a "hapless" life compared to those of her sisters, and as "a case of illicit love" by her nieces (104).

A Plurality of the Subaltern Woman

So far, I have attempted to present a working understanding of Spivak's dense essay on subalternity. The most pertinent (and perhaps most troubling) reflections to be gleaned, in my view, from the Spivak is first, the impossibility of representing the subaltern whose identity-as-difference, by definition, evades a categorization based on normative similarities. In the case of the subaltern as a woman, this enterprise will not stand without reducing her to "a monolithic collectivity of 'women' in the list of the oppressed who [have] unfractured subjectivity" (73). Second, an attempt in the converse would entail an abandonment of the monolith through the assertion of a deeply personal identity by an individual subaltern woman — here, Bhuvaneswari Bhaduri — to subvert the narratives written onto her, not through language but through her body. Terribly, this endeavour reduces her legacy to a regression into those very same narratives she overthrows; worse, the failure to recognise the gravity of her action is reflected in other women who share the burden of subalternity with her. The fact that her nieces believe her suicide to be due to an illicit love affair in the retrospect may perhaps point to her own sisters as the site of this misrecognition. So, on the one hand, the subaltern woman cannot reach for a collective identity without coalescing and erasing her (and her sisters') personhood; on the other, she cannot individuate her own body and selfhood without being grossly thrust back (by her sisters) into the colonial and patriarchal gazes she tries to subvert. In the following section, I posit that Djebar's 'Women of Algiers in their Apartment' offers us an opening between these two difficulties that Spivak leaves us with. Through its discontinuous narrative style that assimilates and consolidates feminine identity and gaze in the space of the bathouses, Djebar's Algerian women create and embody both selfhood and sisterhood.

Djebar's novella gives voice to the stories of a multitude of women in post-independent Algeria. These women are introduced in the text through their relationships with men: Ali's dream opens the narration that shifts the gaze to Sarah (5-6), the *hazab*'s biography paves the way for the biographies of his wives and daughters (10), Nazim's flight from home is the precursor to the

introduction of the characters Aïcha and Baya (12-13). The socio-cultural markers that are denoted in relating the women to the men — as wives, daughters, sisters, employees, neighbours — are only a brief starting acknowledgement in the much richer tapestry of interpersonal connections that span these women's lives. We are engulfed in the lives of Sarah, who was one of the bomb-carrier women at the forefront of the Algerian revolution, Anne, a pied noir Frenchwoman and Sarah's childhood friend who has returned to visit Algiers after fifteen years, Baya, a young academic and biological researcher, Fatma, an ex-sex worker and the water-carrier at the bathhouse, and Leila, the ex-heroine who was imprisoned like Sarah during the Revolution.

Djebar, through her text, goes on to suffuse the women with such deep pluralities of interiority that it casually detaches them from the colonialist and patriarchal gazes imposed on them. The reader is not positioned as perceiving the subaltern from the 'outside'; rather, with little compunction, the reader is left to finding footing across the shifting points of view of each woman. This constantly shifting perspective takes the form of a discontinuous chain of narration. Formally, this discontinuity is visible in the sections of the novella: the four numbered parts are interspersed by two interludes and two 'diwans', or collections of poetry which here become simply a collection of self-expressions. The multiple ellipses (…) that encroach on the orthography of the words (44-45) depict the "severed sound" (147) of the women as they confront the limits of their self-expression. The instability of space is thus visually encoded onto the page; within the text itself, an instability of space is created by the persistent conflation of the domestic house onto the imagery of a prison (15, 23, 50).

Instability is inscribed *within* each section where the point of view also shifts from one character to another – Ali's waking thoughts are overtaken by Sarah's conversation with Anne with the sentence "The telephone." (6), Baya takes up reflection on Nazim's departure after Ali (14), Leila's sudden presence in the text bridges Ali and Sarah's respective narrations (22). Further, there is an instability in the dialogue of the text across language, from French to Berber to colloquial Arabic to the remembered feminine Arabic of native women's songs. The shift from one language to another is not reconciled for us through the translated English of the text — rather, it becomes more evident through the interruptions of the narrative that signify the need for a multiplicity of languages, as in

Nazim's "helpless gesture [as he] turned around to look for a bilingual nurse" (12), Ali's call for Baya to translate Nazim's note, her subsequent apologetic comment on how "full of imagery" Arabic is (13), Anne's need for constant translation (24, 25, 30), the intrusion of a woman into Baya and Sarah's conversation simply because she "understood French", her subsequent switch to Berber to confirm Baya's "regional origins" (34).

This narrative instability becomes most pronounced when, within the point of view of one character, the ghost of the past hanging over her intrudes into the lived present moment. This instability is best seen in *For a diwan of a water carrier*, where the stream-of-consciousness autobiography of Fatma's narration is punctuated by the manipulation of her body in the ambulance (37-43). Her repeated question-declaration of her status, "I am — am I — I am the Excluded One…" (38), here recalls Spivak's subaltern figure, but her self-expression is not an "unfractured subjectivity" (Spivak, 73). Instead time, and hence narration, becomes instable and fractures within the apparent unity of Fatma's character: she cites tradition and religion in the invocation of the Prophet and his widows (38), she drags out her own history and geographies of displacement across her father's farm, her husband's house, and the escape to the urban city (40-41). At the same time, this fracturing is precisely what allows us to glimpse, as the Other, the figure of the subaltern — the half-finished sentences and imagery in Fatma's narration signify "prehistoric words…words that oppress no longer" (38). Yet these words do not become a void utterance or a misrecognised gesture attributed to a history of subjugation, as in Bhuvaneswari's case. For Fatma, these "liberated words [are] following [her] old sculptress body" (37); in other words, Fatma's expression is irrevocably embodied. This extract showcases Djebar's extraordinary move: she does not depart from Spivak, instead she underwrites the figure of the subaltern into the cracks, the instabilities.

Djebar thus writes the individuation of the subaltern as a woman – now, the question of the collective identity of the subaltern stands. I posit that it is the bathhouse, where of course Fatma is also subjugated and is the site of her injury, that provides a space for the subaltern as Algerian women to approach the formations of a community which consolidate feminine identity. The bathhouse, significant in its uniqueness as the only public space some women are allowed to even exist in, brings together a plurality of women that cuts across demographic differences of age, class, race, and

ethnicity. The importance of the bathhouse where “the woman laid down their everyday burdens, their weariness” (31) and its “the water that streams, that sings, that gets lost, that sets us all free, if only bit by bit” (32) is such that women take to breaking the plumbing in their own houses in order to be allowed to visit the bathhouse. These women, only allowed outside for these visits, are “mute, stare at the each other across the streams” (32).

Here then, within the bathhouse, the female gaze is deployed to *look* — which is to penetrate, to consolidate, to recognise, and to validate — other female identities. The space of the bathhouse is remarkable in the very exposure of these gazes, past the veil, which permits an embodiment of the feminine. This embodiment is necessarily deroticised – the dissolution of the erotic charge of the nude female body demythicises the patriarchal narrative by eradicating masculine gaze, the detachment from the veil demythicises the colonialist imperative by secularizing the nation-state. Yet, this embodiment is what prevents a homogenizing assimilation of the subaltern Algerian woman: the differential struggle under hegemonic subjugation is violently marked onto each body – Sarah’s scar, Fatma’s wrinkles, even Baya’s conspicuous lack of them (34) betrays her youth outside of the revolution point to their differentials.

Djebar manages to articulate a subaltern identity through the apertures of the decorated Aristotelian literary unities, which we might as well call the primitive version of the essentialist Eurocentric gaze that Spivak exposes. The subaltern woman is thus granted both an individuating selfhood outside of the forces of totalizing white gaze and the traditionalist patriarchal gaze. Spivak’s subaltern, which forecloses itself from the question of community and solidarity because it finds itself by identity-through-difference, is recapitulated in Djebar’s Algerian bathhouse, which spatializes feminine subalternity without homogenizing it through its inherent embodiment of the woman. In this way, the subaltern finds a sisterhood to consolidate its identity without homogenzing itself.

References

Djebar, Assia. *Women of Algiers in Their Apartments*. Translated by Marjolijn de Jager, University of Virginia, 1980.

Fanon, Frantz. "Unveiling Algeria." *A Dying Colonialism*, Grove Press, 1967.

Spivak, Gayatri Chakravorty. "Can the Subaltern Speak?" *Marxism and the Interpretation of Culture*, edited by Cary Nelson and Lawrence Grossberg, Macmillan, 1988.

Appendix

I was asked to write an essay on the intersection of two beautiful and powerful texts, one by a Muslim woman and one by an Indian woman. I have done it; but I have to say that I could not do it without circling around the unspoken figure that can take the place of this intersection: the Indian Muslim woman. In other words, me. Othered by gender, othered by race, othered by religion – othered by the very egregious fact of my birth. I want to say that the Muslim woman in India becomes subject to a third layer of oppression by religion, in addition to Spivak's two of patriarchy and colonization, but the truth is that my existence ricochets, strikes, splits and doubles back among these three monoliths of my identity that surround me, piercing my body stuck in-between. The veil, rather than take the place of race as in Djebar, overrides it in the case of Indian Muslim woman; the lack of the veil invites condescending praise, 'your family must be progressive'. This word, 'progressive'. It loses any ounce of meaning and purpose once you ask the question: *What exactly are we progressing toward?* Any number of answers: freedom of expression, right to self-determination, emancipation from authoritarianism, is corrupted by colonialism — not just in the ideals of the Western modernity it presupposes, but by the very legal terminology that was granted to us by the British Penal Code. The woman who wears a sari is reclaiming her culture and heritage, the woman who wears the veil is single-handedly thrusting the country back into the slavery of indigo farmers. With, of course, very little reference to the farmers who are *actually* being exploited not a hundred kilometres outside the city; who, in any case, would probably spit at my veil. It never ends. It really never ends. They eat our biryani, they sing our ghazals, they display the remains of a clay sheesha in their museums[1], hail all of these things in the bid for a rich cultural heritage — and they forget me. My existence is always in the past tense. Islam is a smooth, undivided and indestructible blade to their culture, better left to their neighbours, to the margins of their maps, to turn their hostile gazes towards across fences of barbed wires. Across borders. Nevermind that this blade was forged by a three-word policy[2] in 1905 in the face of centuries of coexistence. Nevermind that the components of the blade are scattered across your geography, desperate to live. My religion encroaches on my eyes, lined with kajal, and my hands, stained with henna, only hostile because of the phases of the moon[3].

[1] Red Fort Archaeological Museum, New Delhi.
[2] 'Divide and rule'.
[3] The moon on Diwali is a new moon, the moon on Eid is a full moon.